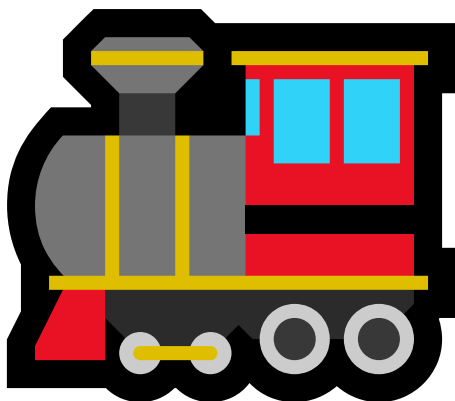


# A Train Ride Around the World

A story about train rides and talking animals



Marco was a carpenter from Great Britain, and that was enough.

He spent most of his days helping his father carry logs from the workshop to Stonebridge Station, wiping sweat from his brow as he listened to Finn speak. In fact, he was carrying one right now. The black crow perched on his head, like an extension of his black hair, which everyone seemed to grow accustomed to. “The wagon is on the left,” Finn crowed, like a crisp paper bag.

His left was the train: red and glorious, smoke rising from its nose, its iron body stretching further than five English oaks would stand. “But a wagon doesn’t crank and whistle, doesn’t it?” Marco replied.

Finn croaked in a raspy voice, one like sawing wood. That was supposedly his laugh. The crow could mimic the language of men with perfection, sometimes speaking better than Marco did.

But there was no point in learning all that. Living in a train station, carpentry and decent social skills were enough for one boy’s life. People often asked where his woodwork was, but Marco had none to offer. But he knew how to use a drill, a measuring tape, a chisel, and all the other equipment. Should that not qualify him as a carpenter?

When you carry planks around the station all day, you have all the time in the world to observe—and that was what Marco did, not the useless lies that Finn blabbered, but the flow of men and women in and out of the train, all dressed in the

languages that the world wanted to speak. Stonebridge station brought the world to the boy himself, and that was enough.

“Excuse me, trainboy!” a man’s voice called out to him, young and humble. Marco turned to his left, careful not to disrupt the river of men with his plank. The man was an explorer, clearly looking for his way. “To which way does Westminster go?”

Finn rasped at him, which made the explorer jump. Marco poked his chin, looking over the gates out of the station. He pointed, “That one, third gate from the left, where the roof is chipped. Take the left turn by the intersection, and it should be a twenty-minute walk. However, if you’re looking for the Big Ben, I recommend taking that gate right next to it, and just follow the road ahead. You can see the clock’s face immediately from that side.”

The explorer was marveled. “So that way is faster?”

Marco nodded.

“Thank you, trainboy!” the explorer said, winking at him. A light magically twinkled from his eye as he did. Before Marco could question him, the explorer had ran off, chasing for the gate Marco had suggested to him.

“Wood!” Finn rasped, kicking Marco back into motion. An extension was being built by the northeast corner of the station, so the workers needed their wood. Stonebridge Station would need to be big; Marco heard that the railway stretched all around the world. He was in awe and he thought a lot about riding it, but the train was no place for a carpenter like him.

Marco kicked his foot up to pass over the stanchion, and the other foot too, and jogged a little faster. He reached the construction site with the sound of hammering and yelling, and he dropped the planks with its friends by the stack. Marco wiped another sweat from his forehead and gazed up, looking to where the hammering came from.

No wonder people were yelling. That man had been hammering the same nail over and over, sitting by the unfinished wall frame. Marco peered closer and realized that the man held the hammer too close to its head. That wasn't enough leverage. Then, the man hammered down right on the nail, only for him to pluck it back out and toss it away—bah!

Marco flinched, hearing the nail land beside where he stood. He saw that no one was paying attention to that man's troubles. "Hey!" he shouted, "Worker, you, up there!"

The man up there turned his head down, investigating where the noise came from, when he finally found Marco. That call caught other workers' attention. The man up there did not seem to catch what Marco said.

"You're hammering it wrong!" Marco shouted. "You're holding the hammer too close to the head, and that won't give you enough leverage. Hitting harder will only make the nail bend. Instead, you should hold it at the end. Try!"

There was silence. All the workers paused with their tools, looking at him.

“Who do you think you are, trainboy!” the man shouted up there, his voice echoing loud enough for everyone to hear. “You’re no carpenter—get out of here, or I’ll drop this hammer to flatten that big nose of yours!”

The other workers chuckled, continuing with their work. Marco’s heart ached a little, but he left the construction site, as instructed by that man, passing over the stanchion and walked through the river of men. It seemed some of the passersby had heard it as well, staring at Marco as he walked.

“His hammer is wrong! Hammer wrong!” Finn rasped.

“Shut it, Finn,” Marco said. “You are being loud.”

A construction site was no place for a boy, so obviously he wouldn’t understand a thing. He wasn’t a carpenter; he was just a boy who brought wood around the station, all dusty and foolish. Why should he go around telling workers what to do? He looked so foolish.

He should’ve just stayed where he was.

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Marco fell into a nap inside a wagon when, minutes later, he heard a commotion outside.

“Wake up, Marco!” Finn shouted.

The dark corners of the storage room greeted his eyes. Empty shelves all around were covered in webs and dust, and it was dim in there—nice and cozy—light seeping from the door to

create a balance of shadow. He rubbed his eyes awake and climbed out of the wagon, dropping his feet onto the ground. Perhaps there had been an injury outside, but what was he to care about?

He peeked outside anyway as Finn perched on his hair. A crowd of hatted men and women gathered outside the train, though it was unclear what the commotion was about. The workers looked completely fine in the northeast corner, but they were looking as stunned.

“It’s probably technical difficulties,” Marco said, returning to his dark storage room. He wanted to nap more and ... stay quiet a little longer.

Finn hovered over to the side of the wagon, watching him climb. “Won’t you check the problem? You know a lot, don’t you?”

“No, I don’t,” Marco replied grimly. He stuffed himself back into the wagon and shut his eyes from the light. The commotion, however, kept on growing, the noise brushing around his ears. He clasped them, muffling the noise just enough for peace. Tonight, after the third break, he’d have a shift to do, so he needed rest.

“Wake up, Marco,” Finn shouted.

“Shut it, crow. I need to sleep!”

“You can’t sleep, Marco,” Finn said, flapping his wings. “You need to help them.”

“I wouldn’t be able to help,” Marco replied, though he did not ask for the tear to seep out. “I’m not a carpenter, nor am I an engineer, nor any of that. I’m a trainboy who carries wood around.”

“You let one worker’s word say who you are?” Finn replied. The more he talked, the more the sound of the commotion rose, flooding his ears.

“More like *all* the workers!” he lashed, smashing a fist onto the side which shook the wagon.

Finn flapped his wings to stay balanced, looking down at Marco while he lay on his back. *God, it looks like I’m lying in my coffin.* He must’ve scared the crow with his outburst. His heart was beating in his chest, his breath going quicker, his mind unstable. Marco slowed his breath down, cooling off from the heat.

Finn usually had many things to say. This time, he was silent. The commotion grew unbearable, impossible for Marco to ignore. The boy looked at the crow once more, eyes resolute, full of hope. And so, he climbed out of the wagon. “Come on, Finn.”

The crow croaked a few times as he perched back onto Marco’s hair. Marco ran outside and shot towards the train. He slowed down by the crowd, listening in to the voices. People were angry that their rides were late, that the train wasn’t moving. Then, Marco searched for the train conductor, a man in a blue hat.

Finn crowed. “Conductor! Conductor!”

Marco turned left, and found the conductor fanning his face with his hat, pacing back and forth as the people gave worried looks toward him. Marco chased for that man.

“Sir!” Marco said, startling the man at his place. “What’s the problem with the train?”

“I ...” The conductor looked nervous, fidgeting everywhere. “Well, the train seemed to have malfunctioned. And for everyone’s safety, I thought it’d be best if everyone stay off the train for now.”

Marco frowned. The conductor was a new face, so perhaps he’d been a new worker. Marco darted towards the train cab and pulled the conductor by his cuffs. “Come on.”

Marco clung and climbed up the train, entering the cab. There were gears and levers everywhere, twisted and turned in all directions. It made his head spin. He heard the conductor’s nervous steps behind him, but there seemed to be no problem at all with the cab, at least nothing serious. Although he had *never* ridden a train before, and—

“Boy, what are you doing?!” a man yelled from behind. Marco turned back and found a man standing by the cab door, pushing the conductor aside. “The train’s currently malfunctioning—you need to get off, now!”

Marco’s breathing began to quicken. What if it *had* been a dangerous matter? What *did* he know about the train? No, the



people were unreasonably panicked because they did not know the way of steam trains. Marco ignored him, scanning the cab for any oddities, but nothing seemed wrong. That was impossible; otherwise, the train would be moving.

Then Marco remembered. His job was to carry wood, including firewood for the train. So, Marco ducked down and slammed the firebox open. A wave of heat shot out, boiling his face.

The conductor yelped in fear and escaped from the train cab, accidentally bringing the man with him on the way out. Finn cackled as he alighted to the doorway, watching them scam. Their voices vanished as Marco investigated the firebox. The fire *was* on, but the train wasn't moving. He took a deep breath and put his head down, scanning inside the firebox as the heat burned his face.

"Clinkers!" Marco shouted, then scrambled for a fire iron, the long steel tool to remove melted ash inside the firebox. It had obstructed the airway from reaching the glowing coal, preventing the fire from igniting. He found the fire iron on the ground, snatched it, and slid it inside the firebox. Then, he jabbed the clinker inside the firebox multiple times, clearing the obstruction little by little.

He was shot with thrill when the fire began to light, and the train began to sound. He might've heard some gasps outside. He just needed to keep jabbing!

"Marco!" Finn called.

Marco drove the fire iron deeper inside the firebox, clearing more and more of the melted ash. The fire was resurrected, and the train soared back to life!

“Marco!” Finn yelled, croaking at him multiple times.

Suddenly, the train cranked into motion, dropping Marco backwards to the ground. Shock ran through him, the horrifying realization of what he’d just done. The boy scrambled to his feet, looking out the cab to see the train moving, *leaving* all the passengers at the station as they all gazed at him, shouting. *Shouting.*

Marco yelled. “C—Conductor! Hop on! Help me—!”

No, he looked too scared. No one else knew how to conduct a train, and they were all too scared to hop on a moving train to help. Marco turned to scan the gears and switches, looking for the one that might stop the train. But, *god*, what would these switches do?! Marco was scared to touch any of it.

“Finn!” Marco yelped. The crow was standing on the open window frame, revealing how fast they were moving. The landscape was sliding past them, trees and hills flying by. The boy was panicking. What had he done?! “Do you know how to stop the train?!”

“No, Marco. No, I don’t,” Finn replied.

The boy began to cry. He would be arrested for this. He imagined the train crashing into another, shattering into pieces. He’d cause deaths and losses, and he’d waste work that men

had done crafting this beauty. Should he leap out of the train onto the grasslands and disappear? He could find another place to work, in another country.

Marco fell onto the floor, watching the station leave him. The train ride around the world would take a while. He might starve before he reached the first destination—no, before he *crashed* into the first destination.

Succumbed in despair, the boy laid still on the ground, helpless, crying. He was a fool. A fool. He shut himself from the world and tried to vanish from it. Darkness- he felt comfortable in it. Darkness.

And soon, he fell asleep.

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“Marco?” Finn called out in the darkness.

He stayed within the darkness. Last time he rose awake, he’d caused disasters. How many hours had it been? How many days? Had the boy died? Had he been arrested?

“We’re in our first station,” Finn said.

Marco’s eyes shot awake. He wore a simple tunic and trousers, and the coldness shot through his skin. Sunlight seeped through the train’s window, the dawn calling for him. He smelled fresh air flowing from outside the cab. From where he laid, he could only see the bright sky—sunny. It looked magical that the sun could be this bright. “Where ... are we?” Marco muttered. He stood up, but felt weak all the way.

Finn didn't answer. Instead, he flew out of the cab and perched on the train's railing outside. Marco followed outside and—

He was in the mountains.

The horizon stretched as far as the world. The green hills rolled beneath him, the landscape twisting up and down as if free from Earth. The clouds covered portions of the hills like a soft blanket for the beautiful trees residing in the valleys. Freedom. He felt freedom in this paradise, as if he could jump straight into the sky and soar endlessly.

Then, he turned left, and could immediately tell where he was. *The Great Wall of China*. That beast of a wall stretched fields and fields and fields across the rolling hills, impossibly circumnavigating through the inclines and the peaks. A wall of stone shouldn't be this flexible, nor this long. But yet it did, as if God placed it here Himself. Marco was breathless.

The station here was old, stone, and viney, sitting by the side of the hill, but not a part of the great wall. Marco clung to the railing and leaned forward, seeing that there were indeed railways extending from behind and beyond the train, navigating a path through the hills.

Nervously, Marco stepped off the train and landed on the station, whatever the station was named. It looked completely abandoned, with no people around, yet it felt more alive than Stonebridge Station ever could. He walked past the empty benches and pillars. "The train won't leave me here, right?"

Finn croaked. "I hope not."

“How did you stop it?”

“I did not.”

Marco was baffled. Was this a dream? It felt too real to be a dream. He brushed his hands together, feeling it was real indeed—warm, comforting. Then Finn suddenly crowed, and it made Marco look forward. Something was sitting by a bench ahead, something *golden*. Marco halted. “Could you check what that is, Finn? Keep your distance.”

Finn obliged and flew in a circular path. It didn’t seem to alert the thing as Finn quickly returned to his hair. “A monkey, blue and gold.”

Marco lurked towards it. It was completely still on the bench, as if sleeping. “Is it dangerous?” he whispered, though Finn didn’t reply. He moved over to a better angle. It was a monkey, as Finn said, quite regal in the way it was dressed, eyes gently shut, probably adrift in its sleep. Its skin was like a soft lapis, covered in golden fur. “Hello?” Marco called for the monkey.

The monkey slowly rose awake, sitting up. “Mother?” he muttered.

“No, I’m Marco,” he replied.

“Oh,” the monkey whimpered. He seemed awfully sad. “Have you seen my family?”

Marco breathed in. “No, I haven’t.” He watched the monkey climb to the ground and walk away, but Marco called after him. “Who are you?”

The monkey stopped and turned to him. “My name is Jin. I am a Golden Snub-nosed Monkey, and I’m looking for my family.”

“You don’t know where they are?” Marco asked.

“No I don’t. I was chasing a bird. I caught it, but I got lost.” Jin returned to walking away, back arched and his tail dragging after.

Finn croaked. “Dangerous! We should leave him be.”

Marco obviously disagreed. “Jin!” he called again, and the monkey turned his head back. “We can help you return to your family!”

The monkey twisted the rest of his body towards him as Finn crowed in objection, pecking his head a few times. “Really?!” Jin said. “How are you going to do it?”

“Finn is going fly around the mountains to look for your family, right Finn?” Marco asked.

Finn croaked in dissent, but a croak meant a yes.

And so, Finn flew away without question, gliding over the mountains in circles and perching inside trees on different parts of the mountain, while he and Jin watched from the station. The mountains were always a beautiful sight.

After a few minutes of waiting, Marco spotted the crow flying back towards him. Marco put a hand up, but Finn landed on his head instead. “They should be here any second now.”

Ahead of them, Marco heard twisting and shuffling of branches and leaves. Another Golden Snub-nosed Monkey climbed up the station's floor, one that was bigger and more mature. Plenty more came after them, climbing up the station floor and standing in a line. All five of them looked gorgeous, magical in their golden fur.

Jin shot forward, embracing the biggest one in a hug. They all piled together, demanding that Jin explain why he had disappeared. Soon after they settled down, the most mature one of them stepped towards Marco and Finn. "I am their mother. Thank you for bringing my son back to us. Please take this as our thanks."

The mother monkey took a basket of colorful fruits from one of them and slid it towards Marco. The monkeys made their farewells as they returned to the forest along with Jin, leaving Marco and Finn alone on the station. They sat on the bench, enjoying the sweet, ripe fruits to themselves.

"I wish my father would treat me like that," Marco said, swallowing the fruit.

"He is still there with you in the station, isn't he?" Finn said.

Marco gazed at the great wall running through the hills, and then the train. He had been dying to climb that, but he'd seen no way of getting up. And ... if this train could return, perhaps he'd have someone waiting for him back there.

They returned back to the cab of the train, along with the basket of fruits.

As they sat inside, the train magically began to whistle and jump into motion. Marco opened the firebox, and saw that the fuel was still alight. “Did you put the firewood in there?” Marco asked, though Finn shook his beak.

Marco rested and let the train bring him to his next destination. He watched the hills roll past him, though from the speed, Marco could tell the ride would take a while. At least he had fruits to replenish himself now.

Soon, Marco napped and drifted back to sleep. He’d find a way to return.

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He woke up at night, still in the middle of the railway. The train cranked and hammered, wheels slamming against the rails—the beautiful sound of a train. He felt more replenished than ever, getting up to his feet and joining Finn, who was watching the view by the window. “Where are we now?” Marco asked.

“Finland, at the very northern tip,” Finn said, almost blending in with the night. His feathers were as dark as the pine forests, and if not for the snow, Finn would’ve been completely camouflaged. “I have a good feeling of where we’re heading.”

Marco peeked out and was suddenly hoarded by a rush of cold. Icy cold. He pulled back and returned to the warmth. Turning over, he realized that the firebox had kept him warm throughout his nap. Outside was at freezing temperature. “I can’t get out in this weather.”



The crow croaked, or was that a laugh? Soon after, the train began to slow down, and they stopped by a station—another one that looked abandoned. The station was dark, covered in snow, and there was no way to walk there without stumbling on layers of snow.

“Can we skip this one?” Marco asked.

“No, we can’t. We should go out.”

“I’ll freeze to death!”

Finn stared at him on the ground, huddling close to the firebox. Never had he thought that he would find home next to an active firebox. Finn, standing on the window, was gazing outside, as if yearning for it. It was easy for a crow like him to venture out into the snow. “I think I see light,” Finn said. “An inn is nearby. If you make a run—”

“And then what?” Marco said. He refused to budge.

The crow seemed down. He flapped his wings and alighted on one of the gears, away from the window. “So ... we go?” he said, sounding disappointed.

“I’ll die in the cold, Finn. I can’t.”

The train whistled, kicking back into motion, which surprised Marco. They were moving. “You can control the train?” Marco asked, standing back up.

“No, I think ...” Finn said, scanning the gears that had automatically spun on their own. “I think it depends on *our*

will. Marco watched the station moving further from them, a place that they, unfortunately, could not explore. Marco was relieved, he wanted to get out of here quick.

As they sat, Marco looked at Finn, who, even though moved further from the window, still gazed at the view beyond it, passing them by. He looked completely normal, but Marco began to question whether that expression was ... okay. Finn always seemed confused when Marco acted a certain way. Could it be that it was the same the other way around?

Tempted to say something, Marco followed his gaze, watching the trees pass by. Slowly, the trees running by began to thin, revealing more and more of the night sky far ahead. But as it revealed itself, Marco noticed the sky far ahead wasn't dark blue; instead, it was green, and teal, and pink, all swirling together harmoniously to create a symphony in the sky. And—

It vanished back behind the trees. Marco stood up and clung to the window despite the freezing temperature. *Aurora Borealis!* He chased for another look, but too many trees were in the way. As his head began to freeze in the fast winds, he pulled back into the cab. The train was heading the opposite way from the sky, and there didn't seem to be an end to the flow of pine trees around them. He had missed it. He ...

He glanced at Finn, who was simply standing there.

"I'm sorry Finn, I should've gone. I should've listened," Marco said, facing the ground.

The crow croaked.

And what did that say about Marco himself? “Okay,” he said, sitting back down by the firebox.

*Why did I think that it would be pointless? How many things have I missed that I deemed pointless?*

Pondering in his thoughts, Marco this time stayed awake, while Finn drifted asleep. He stood on a high gear and tucked his neck in, closing his eyes.

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The night turned into day, and it was hot—scorching hot. Instead, Marco found himself distancing from the firebox, in the corner where he just avoided the sunlight. The basket of fruits was beginning to empty itself.

Finn began to flap his wings to indicate he was awake. Soon, they stopped by the station.

Last time, it'd been icy cold. This time, it was scorching hot. Without waiting, Marco climbed back up to his feet and walked out of the cab and into the station. The sun briefly cooked his skin, and even after reaching shade in the station, Marco felt the heat lingering. While the last ones were made of stone, this one was made of sandstone, yellow and orange and more rough in texture.

Finn perched onto his hair. “How are we going to find anything here?” They were in the desert, surrounded by endless dunes. The horizon was twisting and dancing in the heat, and the sand baked his sandals. “Can you handle this heat, Finn?”

“Hot. Really hot. But I can handle being out there for half an hour,” Finn replied. “And turn around, Marco.”

He did so and found that the Pyramid of Giza had been right there all along. The beast stood in the middle of the desert, as if challenging the sun itself. However, the remarkable size only emphasized the distance they’d need to walk. There had to be supplies there, and Marco had an idea. “Step off for a moment,” he said.

Finn obliged, alighting onto the sandstone. Marco removed his tunic shirt and hung it over his head, leaving space for Finn to hang around on his upper arm, under the shade. Finn did so, and shuffled around to find a comfortable spot—his feathers brushing over Marco’s cheek. When they were ready, they stepped out onto the hot desert and made their way towards the pyramid.

It was midway towards the pyramid when Marco realized he probably should’ve brought fruits. His tongue had dried, and his body was mildly sweating. Finn croaked at him, “It’s terribly damp in here.”

“That’s supposed to be a good thing, isn’t it—cooling you off from the heat?” Marco said.

“I suppose so,” Finn said. “I can’t help but notice your steps are beginning to sway a lot.”

“Is it?” Marco asked. Things felt completely fine and upright to him, though his feet began to weigh like bricks. The pyramid was just ahead, perhaps a ten-more-minute walk. Marco

gasped. Perhaps this had been a foolish idea, but last time he rejected one of those, he'd regretted it. He didn't know how this one would—

Marco dropped one knee to the sand, the heat crawling through his trousers and onto his knees. Finn flapped his wings inside to maintain balance, slapping his face repeatedly, but ended up flying out anyway. He was drenched in sweat, and his heart was racing. Then, it suddenly hit him—he became lightheaded, unable to balance himself.

Arms felt weak at his sides, and he had to clasped his hand over his head to keep it hanging over his shoulders. Finn landed on the sand for a moment, right beside his knee. “Stay here!” And vanished out of sight.

Marco wanted to lay on the ground, but he would begin to cook like an egg. Marco was gasping for breath, overheated, disoriented. He felt sick. The most he could do was sit down and let his legs rest while his head was throbbing. He shouldn't have gone here. He should've stopped and return, knowing this heat.

He kept his head down and counted his seconds, when suddenly a shadow was casted over him, putting him in a shade. Marco glanced to his sides, seeing two pairs of hooves standing right there. He was too weak to lift his head, but whatever it was, it was protecting him.

Soon, Finn returned, hopping on the sand while carrying a small pear by its beak. Quickly, Marco laid his shirt cover

across the sand, snatching the pear and collapsed down. The pear was half the size of his palm, which was impressively hefty to be carried by a crow. Marco bit a piece and handed it over to Finn.

“I’ve had mine back at the train. Please treat yourself.”

Marco couldn’t reply; he couldn’t think. All he knew was that above him had been a camel, seeing its hairy chest as his rooftop. Finn was likely talking to the camel, though remaining in the shade right beside him. Marco took bites of the pear and sank his head onto his shirt cover.

Minutes passed as Marco recovered his strength. The camel was still standing above him. “Camel,” Marco called, which startled Finn. “Thank you, Camel!”

“Mmm, you’re welcome,” the camel replied, voice coming from above. Her voice was low and rubbery. “Dear, why were you walking in the middle of the desert, topless, and without supplies?! If I hadn’t caught you on the way, you would’ve been fried under the sun!”

Only now did Marco realize how silly he must’ve looked. “I wanted to see the Pyramid of Giza!”

Finn turned his head. “Didn’t you say we were seeking supplies?”

Marco blushed. “Erm, that first, and then seeing the pyramid.”

The camel seemed to giggle. “My name is Nasira. I can get you to the pyramid if you want a closer look, but I warn you, there aren’t any supplies there. It’s a *landmark*, not a *settlement*.”

Marco grabbed his shirt, dusting it off the sand, and placed it back over his head as he stepped out onto the heat. Nasira lowered herself onto the ground for him to climb, and Marco hopped comfortably between the two humps. Actually, it wasn’t too comfortable, though it beat walking on hot sand.

“Hold on tight!” Nasira said. Suddenly, as the camel straightened her back legs, Marco was thrown forward, but he held on, almost slipping off the hump. Then, she straightened her front legs, throwing Marco back. He felt sick again, and Finn cackled at him.

The crow sat on the front hump—Marco sharing the shade—and they kicked into motion.

Travelling through the sand, Marco was curious. “Why had you come to help, Nasira?”

“Mmm,” Nasira said, pondering in thought. “It is because that is a camel’s job dear. Our purpose is to bring humans through the desert.” Marco was silent, but Nasira had probably expected a reply from him. “What is *your* purpose, Marco? Mmm.”

“My purpose?” Marco said. “I don’t know.”

“Oh dear,” the camel said, as if it had been an issue. “Well, does Finn know his purpose?”

The crow was silent. “To fly.”

Nasira giggled. “More specific, dear!” she said. “Well, Marco, everyone has a purpose in their life, but it’s okay if you don’t know yet. Perhaps we can begin with ... what you like to do.”

This one, Marco knew how to answer. “I spend my life carrying woods around Stonebridge Station. It’s a train station in Great Britain.”

“And you like it?”

“N—No.” Marco couldn’t believe he just said that.

“So what do *you* like to do, dear?”

“I think I know, but I don’t do it often,” Marco said.

“That’s okay,” Nasira said. Marco was baffled that the camel was completely unaffected by the heat. “And what is it that you would like to do?”

Marco breathed in. “Explore the world, be good at everything.”

Nasira listened. “Well there you have it: that’s your purpose. And you’re doing it right now, aren’t you?”

Marco nodded. He was. Should he feel happy? He didn’t feel anything at the moment, though he reserved that thought to himself.

“What about you, Finn?”

Finn snapped a croak.



Nasira giggled again. “Okay, dear. I’ll stop.” Though, she literally did stop on her path, startling him and Finn.

Marco looked forward—the pyramid had grown twice as tall, and he could grasp the number of fields it covered, stretching across the desert. The titan had more pyramids around it, standing loyal to its former. Further ahead, a giant statue of a cat—a sphinx—sat on the sand, undefeated in size with the rest. Together, under the white blazing streak of the sun, they formed a golden wonder.

The sight was glorious, though he couldn’t stay long before burning in the sun. They soon returned to the station and thanked Nasira for the ride. “No need for compensation,” Nasira said, ready to depart. “Travel safely, okay?”

Marco and Finn looked at each other and headed back for the train. Marco climbed up and entered the train cab, where he threw his shirt on the ground, and ... dropped. He sat in the same corner that provided good shade. Exhausted from the heat, Marco laid flat on the ground, glancing at Finn, who had also immediately fallen asleep on a high gear.

The train whistled and began moving.

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Marco woke up with a churning stomach and a dry tongue. Half-awake, his hand scrambled for the basket, only for it to completely flip over, weightless. Marco shot his eyes open and just remembered they had long ran out of fruits. His mind was

awake, but his body was limp. He stretched while lying on the ground. “Finn?” he mumbled.

The crow was still asleep. Marco was first to wake up again. He sat upright, yawning, and slowly rose to his feet. The sky was still night, moon casting over the sky amidst the spectacle stars. The landscape was clear of any buildings, and he wasn’t certain what landmark would be around here. The field was green but dark, almost difficult to see.

But upon a second look, the seemingly empty and dark field turned out to be rich and dense, full of ripe and fresh crops. They were passing by a corn field!

Marco threw his head out the window, gazing left and right, aghast at how far the cornfield stretched. They spanned field after field, going beyond the horizon. On an empty stomach, Marco grew excited, pulling his head back in. “Finn! Wake up Finn! It’s your favorite food!”

Finn croaked a few times, before flapping his wings. “What?”

Marco gently snatched Finn, causing him to croak in surprise as he gently held the crow between his hands, and brought him by the window. Finn pecked his hands a few times before looking towards the window. He stopped, growing as stunned as Marco was.

As the train reached a stop, Marco immediately jumped off the train—Finn flying behind—and jumped onto the streets. He ran for the field and immediately snatched one corn that looked ripe, tearing the husk from the ear and biting into it. It was

sweet and juicy, a medley in his tongue, its water a blessing for how long they'd stayed dehydrated. Finn was croaking nearby, and without thinking, Marco called out to him.

He ran his teeth through the corn, snapping the kernels from the cob, and spat it onto the ground, where Finn landed and picked it one by one. Marco finished one corn off, throwing the cob aside and snatching another. He was *starving*.

Finn croaked again, demanding for extra, and Marco spat more kernels onto the ground. For minutes, he filled his stomach with corn, losing track of time until he was stuffed.

Marco was sitting on the street beside the field, surrounded by cobs, while Finn was picking a few more kernels. Marco gazed around, seeing that the horizon was completely empty of any buildings, or at least it looked so in the night. "Finn, can you tell where we're supposed to go?"

As Finn finished eating, he hopped towards the further end of the street and looked left and right. "Nope. There is nothing around."

"Then *this* must be our landmark. The cornfield!" Marco said. "We're in North America." Then, he dove into thought—his mind clearer, stuffed with corn. "Our first destination was the Great Wall of China, then Aurora Borealis in Finland, then the Pyramid of Giza in Egypt, and now, the cornfield in the United States of America."

Finn croaked a few laughs. "Cornfield."

“Don’t you see the pattern, Finn?” Marco said. “We’ve passed Asia, Europe, Africa, and North America. Hence, our next destination is—”

“Antarctica,” Finn said, croaking a few laughs again.

That startled him, because it could be true. “I—I hope not,” Marco replied. “It’s either Australia or South America.”

Minutes passed, and it was time to leave. Marco stood up and snatched corn after corn from the field. It would be stealing, but he would’ve been over on the other side of the world by then. After having a handful of them in his arms, he walked back towards the train, ignoring the fallen corn on the way.

Climbing would be difficult, so he rounded the train and walked over to the station, entering the cab from there. Reaching the cab, he dropped all the corn onto the ground. They drummed the floor, completely flooding the ground, but that only made the cab livelier. Finn had perched on the window frame by then.

Marco also saw another potential use, noticing the firebox and the countless corns. “You know, Finn? We could also make roasted corn with the firebox.” Marco found himself grinning at the idea, though he wasn’t sure if that was safe. It should be, right? “Anyway, we’re ready. Let’s go!”

Marco was settling himself on the ground when he noticed the train wasn’t moving. His expression dropped, and he spoke again. “Let’s go!”

The train stayed completely still, no hammering, no whistling. The train worked without command last time, so why had it stopped now? Marco grew nervous. He ducked down and slammed open the firebox, seeing it was still red and glowing, magically fueling itself with each destination they reached. Why wasn't it going?

"Finn," Marco called. Do you know why—

*Finn.*

Marco turned around, seeing Finn perched by the window, gazing at the field, the crow's back towards him. Marco's heart dropped—the *two* would need to agree to get the train moving. Finn was a crow, and where else would he want to live if not ... here? He had never seen Finn interact with any other crows during their time together, and it seemed that Finn recognized this chance. He was yearning for something else, something different from Marco. "... Finn?"

The crow was silent.

"Finn."

The crow croaked. "I sense that my friends are here, Marco. There are other crows nearby; I hear their voices."

"Are you going ... to leave?" Marco said.

"The sky tells me this is where I'm meant to be," the crow said. "This is my home."

Marco stayed on the other side of the cabin, opposite to the crow, feeling powerless. He was going to be alone, but it felt wrong to make him stay. Tears began to fall, his throat tightening. He wanted to say, “Don’t go,” but he couldn’t. What could he say then? “Go.”

The crow made one last croak before flying off, disappearing from the window. Marco gasped at how fast he vanished. He wasn’t ready to see him off, but it was too late. The train whistled and cranked into motion.

Marco made one last look, standing by the door, gazing out over the fields, though he couldn’t see Finn anywhere. “Goodbye, Finn!” Marco yelled, moving further and further from the station, and the place where they ate together.

Long enough after Finn was too far, Marco sat alone inside the cab, with too many crows rolling around his feet, the room dim under the moonlight. Alone.

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South America, Brazil, Christ the Redeemer.

Marco stood by the window frame as the train ran, gazing at the statue standing atop a mountain. The sun shone from the east, splitting the mountain into two shades. The railways ran through the sides of the mountain, so the train had to circumnavigate through the hills. It reminded him of his first destination, but nothing was similar about the way he felt now.

He was traveling closer and closer towards the statue until the train unexpectedly stopped by a station. *In the middle of the forest?*

In the distance, Marco spotted civilization, settling by the sea. Mankind, but he was not looking for that. He needed to find his way through the forest to get to the statue. He put on his shirt and took two coins in each hand for travel.

He navigated through the forest surprisingly with ease. He had overestimated the incline of the hills, thinking that it'd be a two-handed climb. Passing through the trees, not having Finn by his side made things awfully quiet, but he tried to avoid that thought. *He is pursuing his purpose, and so will I.*

On the way there, Marco tucked the corn between his armpit to pick up a branch. It spanned one arm long, and from the heft, he could tell this was hardwood. This one would be tougher to cut or sand, so beginners are often told to work around lightwood instead. Marco tossed that away and continued his journey.

He thought he'd heard shuffling around the trees nearby, but he kept his gaze forward. He stepped across rock after rock, counting which one looked hard and abrasive and which one looked soft and fragile. Usually, the ones that felt like sandpaper were the more abrasive rocks, the ones that were better for sanding.

The trees shuffled again. He turned around, but there was too much foliage in the way. Something was lurking. His heart

quickened, and in a slow, careful decision, he ran! Marco drove his feet to the rocks, leaping over tree after tree, careful not to hit a branch, but urgent to increase his pace. Then, to his horror, something was chasing him from behind, rapid beats against the rocks.

Marco gazed forward. The bridge to the statue was still far ahead; he'd be exhausted long before reaching it. "Help!" Marco yelled, his voice bouncing through the forest. He gasped and yelled again, "Help!"

As he ran, he noticed a thick branch a few feet away from his direction. In a split second, he decided to turn around, grab the hefty stick, and face the animal. Then, his heart flipped.

A jaguar skidded to a stop. Its vicious eyes locked onto him, canine teeth poking out of its mouth as it crawled slowly towards him. Its skin was black and yellow, with the pattern that indicated certain death. The way it navigated the terrain smoothly made Marco doubt his movements in the forest. It growled, rumbling in his chest. Was he going to die? He was going to die, wasn't he?

No, an elite jaguar would've pounced him and crushed his neck in an instant. This one had to be young. Marco peered closer, seeing that the size of the jaguar was comparable to five stacks of planks. He could heave *seven*. Though if he let his guard down, it would only take the beast one bite or a claw to fully wear him down.



His hands were shaking. His neck was at stake. Blood rushed through his head, pumped by his beating chest. And—

The jaguar pounced at him. Marco shoved the long stick towards it, but he was completely thrown backwards, bringing them to a tussle on the ground. Marco kept guard of the beast's jaw, shoving the stick between it and keeping its distance from his neck. He tried to escape—he couldn't escape. The beast had grappled his sides, its claws driving into his skin, keeping him secure to the ground.

He kept fighting, pushing while the beast growled death. The beast couldn't chew through the hardwood, and Marco felt its resistance weakening by the second. The young beast had been slowly draining its strength. So, having preserved his energy, Marco shoved forward, twisting the beast's neck up and imbalanced, and snatched one claw off his side. Then, having better leverage, Marco squeezed his legs inward and drove it straight towards the beast, shoving it away, but the claw tore his sides.

The pain twisted and numbed his head, and Marco almost struggled to stand straight up. Such a simple wound could finish a human, a child. Marco kept fighting, getting on his knees, noting that he had shoved the young jaguar rolling down the incline.

That beast didn't have skin; it had a hide, almost thicker than leather. If he ran now, the beast would simply catch up to him. Instead, Marco limped away, searching on the ground for a stone. Not any ordinary stone; such things would crumple

quickly when sanding a hardwood. He needed a pumice stone, one that was hard and abrasive. Yes, he passed through many of those while walking

In no time, he snatched a good chunk off the ground and began sanding the tip of the hardwood. A blunt end would not even brush the jaguar; thus, he would need a *spear*. The bark chipped off quickly, but its pith was tougher to sand, as expected. He slowly carved the tip of the stick into a sharp, pointy end as he watched the jaguar climb closer. That beast had recovered, while Marco had been scarred.

Marco kept limping away while he sanded it, not towards the statue, but back towards the train. The jaguar lurked closer and closer between the trees, a good eight feet away from him. The spear's end was halfway done, but Marco's arm began to sore from repeated sanding. What of the strength he needed to preserve to fight the jaguar?

The beast crawled forward, its eyes starving for his neck, driven by dangerous predatory instinct. Wait, he could speak to it. "Jaguar, we don't need to fight!"

But it kept growling, unable to understand anything he said. *Why don't they speak now?*

Marco limped backwards, nearly done shaping the tip as the beast crawled almost five feet from him, a good distance for a pounce. Then, Marco hurled the pumice stone towards the young jaguar, angering it, causing it to pounce towards him, and Marco shoved the spear forward.

He was still thrown backwards, unable to withstand the jaguar's strength, but he felt it—he felt *jaguar skin* ripping at the end of his stick. The spear he made was pathetic, barely harming the beast, but the simple scratch was enough to frighten it. It growled at him and leaped away. Marco froze for a long minute, and he cried.

The burning pain returned, and the sides of his shirt began to turn red. Marco understood basic first aid, taking off his shirt and tightening it around his waist to stop the bleeding. The wound looked horrible. He got onto his feet, the spear supporting his weight, and limped back in weak tears and moans.

Long minutes passed, and he couldn't be more glad to see the station a little far ahead. He had to get out of here quick.

He gazed back towards the statue of Christ the Redeemer one last time, admiring its towering beauty, touching the sky itself, before reaching the station and hopping into the cab. There were still too many corns on the floor of the cab, but he'd grown back an appreciation of each one. "Let's go," Marco said.

The train whistled and cranked into motion. Marco sighed in relief, dropping onto the floor. He set the spear beside him, its tip grazed with blood, and began peeling a corn. He bit into it and confirmed that the kernels were still fresh and—

Something landed at the back of the train, shaking the metal. His heart dropped, his hands immediately snatching the spear

beside him. He swallowed the corn and watched the tender, the storage car directly behind his. He was still hesitant. It couldn't be the jaguar again.

He couldn't stand up. The wound had drained all the strength from his legs, still twisting and knotting in pain. Marco watched tensely as a yellow-and-black-patterned beast emerged from the top of the tender. The jaguar had somehow leapt onto the moving train, back to finish him off.

Marco was cornered, immobile, exposed, wounded. He couldn't ... He ...

He grabbed the fire iron next to him, slammed open the fire box, and drove the tool inside. The beast growled again, crawling closer and closer towards the cab, eyes locked onto him. When Marco pointed the spear, it only glanced at it. Had it learned to ignore it?

All he needed to do was stall the beast as the fire iron heated up. As a last resort, Marco tried talking to him one last time. "Jaguar! Why won't you talk to me?"

But it didn't work.

Almost a minute passed, and Marco hurled the spear towards the jaguar. It simply lashed it away, and seeing him defenseless, it pounced.

Marco pulled out the fire iron and drove the hot end towards the jaguar. It growled; it panicked, unable to fight off the fire

iron, sizzling in its skin. And at last, the beast fled, scurrying away with a burn on its chest and jaw.

Marco slid the fire iron back into the firebox in case the beast returned, though he allowed himself to finally rest—if he could make it back with this wound. He laid down, and after long enough, rested the fire iron from the heat, and drifted asleep.

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And so, he woke up to a familiar air. The cloudy sky and the empty grasslands, it was everything he remembered. The journey felt surreal, and perhaps it had been. Had it ended already?

Marco clung to the door and pulled himself up, an arm on his side. The train was nearing Stonebridge Station, and he saw the crowd of people waiting there. This was the end; he had circled the world.

However, Marco had to check one thing. He slammed the firebox open and saw that it had nearly gone out. The train wasn't going to work by itself any longer. Marco looked at the cab's gears and levers, and they didn't look that much overwhelming anymore. Marco *had* been observing which gears did what. It was what he was good at, wasn't it?

Marco pulled the brake valve, and the train began to slow down, the wheels scraping on the railway. He pulled a cord, causing the train to whistle and announce his return.

The train stopped at the station, and Marco stepped out of the cab. Among the crowd who were aghast at seeing his return, there was his father, waiting for him.

YOUR TRAIN RIDE ENDS HERE

THANK YOU FOR READING

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This one took a bit longer cause I didn't know how to fit the plot into a shorter story. In the end, with the power of time and nothing-else-to-do, I managed to lay it down in the paper. Once again, thank you for reading!